Which airline should the travel desk book by default?

Business recommendation | Domestic airline performance, January to September 2026 | Data: DGCA monthly domestic traffic reports

Recommendation

Book IndiGo by default, with Akasa Air as the primary alternative. IndiGo has the best punctuality (86.02% average on-time performance, highest in all 9 months) and ranks first on the combined scorecard. Confidence is **moderate**: Akasa Air has nearly matched IndiGo on punctuality since July 2026 and has the lower cancellation rate.

The scorecard

Airline	On-time performance	Cancellation rate	Complaints per 10,000 passengers	Score (50/30/20)	Rank	Rank, equal weights
IndiGo	86.02%	0.41%	2.63	1.49	1	1
Akasa Air	80.79%	0.13%	2.52	1.99	2	2
Air India Group	79.50%	0.74%	3.23	2.78	3	3
Alliance Air	70.81%	4.47%	63.57	4.31	4	5
SpiceJet	34.56%	7.39%	4.82	4.42	5	4

Averages over January to September 2026 (10-airport reporting period). Lower score is better; a score of 1.0 would mean first place on every measure in every month.

Does the result depend on the weights? Not for the top three. Under both weightings tested (50/30/20, and equal weights), the top three are the same and in the same order: IndiGo, Akasa Air, Air India Group (equal-weight scores 1.65, 1.87 and 2.85). Only the order of the bottom two changes: Alliance Air and SpiceJet swap places. Only these two weightings were tested.

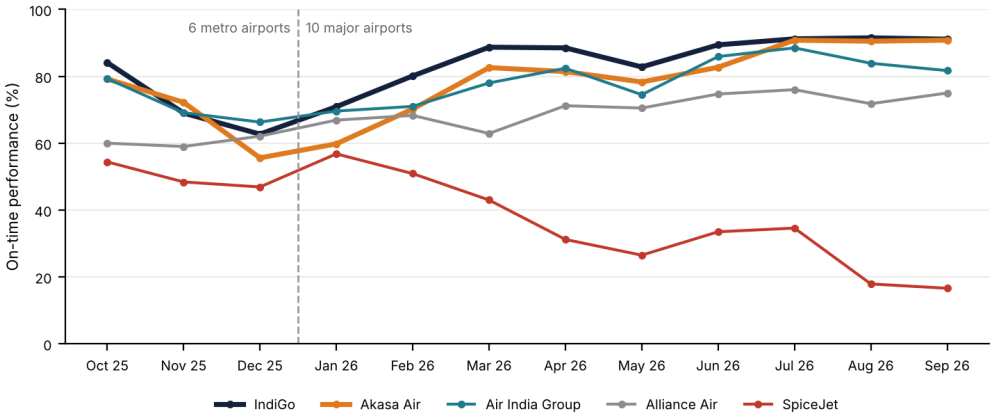
Three key insights

Insight 1: IndiGo is the most punctual airline. It averaged 86.02% on-time performance against 80.79% for Akasa Air and 79.50% for Air India Group, and had the highest on-time performance in all nine months from January to September 2026.

Insight 2: Akasa Air is the most reliable on cancellations and is closing the punctuality gap. Its average cancellation rate was 0.13% against IndiGo's 0.41%, and it was lower in 8 of the 9 months (equal in June). In July, August and September its on-time performance was within one point of IndiGo's (90.8 vs 91.2, 90.5 vs 91.5, 90.8 vs 91.1). Its average complaint rate is marginally lower (2.52 against 2.63 per 10,000 passengers), but IndiGo's complaint rate was lower in each month from April to September.

Insight 3: SpiceJet and Alliance Air should not be default choices. SpiceJet's on-time performance fell from 56.8% in January to 16.6% in September, with a 20.29% cancellation rate that month. Alliance Air averaged 63.57 complaints per 10,000 passengers, against 2.52 to 3.23 for the three leaders.

On-time performance by month



DGCA widened its on-time performance measurement from 6 metro airports to 10 major airports from January 2026 (adding Ahmedabad, Cochin, Guwahati and Lucknow). The dashed line marks the change, so movements across it are not like-for-like. The headline ranking therefore uses only January to September 2026.

How the score works, and how much it matters

Each month, the five airlines with on-time data are ranked on three measures, then the ranks are combined using weights that reflect what disruption costs a corporate traveller: **on-time performance 50%** (missed meetings), **cancellations 30%** (a cancelled flight costs more than a late one) and **complaints 20%** (the noisiest signal, because small airlines carry few passengers). The score is the average of the monthly results.

- **Over all 12 months the lead is thin.** With equal weights, IndiGo scores 1.87 and Akasa Air 1.88, which is effectively a tie. That is why confidence is moderate.

When the recommendation should change

Proposed triggers for reviewing the default (these are suggested thresholds, not industry standards):

- Switch to Akasa Air if its on-time performance matches or beats IndiGo's for two months in a row.
- Review IndiGo if its cancellation rate rises above 1% again. It reached 9.65% in December 2025, with complaints at 31.7 per 10,000 passengers.
- Revisit the whole ranking if the airline's performance on the company's own routes differs from the national figures.

Limits of this analysis

- On-time performance covers major airports only (6 until December 2025, 10 from January 2026). Smaller airports, specific routes and times of day are not visible.
- Ranks show order, not the size of the gaps, and averages are not weighted by passengers. Complaint rates for small airlines are volatile.
- Fly91, Indiaone Air and Star Air have no on-time data and are not in the scorecard. See the scorecard on page 1.
- Ticket prices, schedules and the company's own disruption costs are not included.
- Extraction check: values were extracted from the DGCA PDF charts with code, then a random sample (fixed seed) plus the most extreme values were compared against the PDFs by eye, and all matched. This shows the dataset copies what DGCA published; it does not verify DGCA's own figures.

Recommended next steps before making this company policy

- Test the ranking on the routes the company books most often.
- Compare ticket prices and schedule fit for IndiGo and Akasa Air on those routes.
- Estimate what a delay or cancellation costs the company, to check that the 50/30/20 weights fit.
- Re-run the scorecard each quarter with new DGCA reports.

Business points behind the scorecard

Reasoning for the weights and the recommendation. These points add no new numbers; the weights are my judgement about how disruption affects business travel, not a finding from the data.

Why each measure matters to a travel desk

- **On-time performance (50%).** A business trip has a fixed purpose, such as a meeting, a client visit or a connection. A late arrival can mean a missed meeting, which can cost more than the delay itself. This is why punctuality carries the most weight.
- **Cancellation rate (30%).** A cancellation is worse than a delay: the traveller must rebook, may lose a day, and the company may pay for hotels or last-minute fares. It is rarer than a delay, so it gets a lower weight, but each event hurts more.
- **Complaints per 10,000 passengers (20%).** This reflects service quality (baggage, refunds, staff behaviour). It affects the experience more than whether the trip happens, and small airlines give noisy rates, so it gets the lowest weight.

Why this is a decision, not just a ranking

- The travel desk needs one default, because a default is what most employees will book.
- The recommendation includes a backup (Akasa Air) for when IndiGo's schedule or price does not fit.
- It includes triggers for changing the default, so the policy is reviewed when the data changes.

Business intelligence concepts used

- **KPIs:** on-time performance, cancellation rate and complaints per 10,000 passengers.
- **Normalisation:** complaints are divided by passengers, so large and small airlines are comparable.
- **Weighted scoring model:** several measures combined into one decision, with the weights stated.
- **Sensitivity analysis:** the top three did not change under the two weightings tested.
- **Like-for-like comparison:** the headline ranking uses only the nine months with the same airport coverage.
- **Trend analysis:** averages hide direction; the monthly chart shows SpiceJet falling and Akasa Air catching up with IndiGo. See the chart on page 2.
- **Data validation:** a random sample and the extreme values were compared with the source PDFs.

What the data cannot tell the company

- The right airline depends on the company's own routes; a national average may not match them.
- Reliability is not the only factor. Price, schedule and availability matter too, but were outside this project's scope.